

2. Our siblings, according to speculative reconstructions (top to bottom): *Homo rudolfensis* (East Africa); *Homo erectus* (East Asia); and *Homo neanderthalensis* (Europe and western Asia). All are humans.

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Humans in Europe and western Asia evolved into *Homo neanderthalensis* (‘Man from the Neander Valley’), popularly referred to simply as ‘Neanderthals’. Neanderthals, bulkier and more muscular than us Sapiens, were well adapted to the cold climate of Ice Age western Eurasia. The more eastern regions of Asia were populated by *Homo erectus*, ‘Upright Man’, who survived there for close to 2 million years, making it the most durable human species ever. This record is unlikely to be broken even by our own species. It is doubtful whether *Homo sapiens* will still be around a thousand years from now, so 2 million years is really out of our league.

On the island of Java, in Indonesia, lived *Homo soloensis*, ‘Man from the Solo Valley’, who was suited to life in the tropics. On another Indonesian island – the small island of Flores – archaic humans underwent a process of dwarfing. Humans first reached Flores when the sea level was exceptionally low, and the island was easily accessible from the mainland.